



THE INSTITUTE OF
MASTERS
of WINE

Practical exam report 2019

a) Practical Chair report	Page 2
b) Practical Paper 1	Page 3
c) Practical Paper 2	Page 5
d) Practical Paper 3	Page 8

a) Practical Exam Chair and Chief Examiner – John Hoskins MW

We had 22 passes this year, which was well up on the previous year. However, this was out of 151 candidates, so the pass rate still hovers around 15%. The really good news was the number of clear high passes – 13. Behind those excellent candidates were 37 ‘borderlines’, of whom nine were passed after moderation.

At the other end of the scale, we had a higher number of candidates with very low scores. 30 people got three D grades, or worse, which means not a single paper over 50%. I really do encourage candidates only to sit the exam when they are ready. You have a limited number of attempts so it is unwise (and expensive) to waste one. The statistics show that those getting really low marks on a first attempt rarely ever achieve a pass in the end.

After the exam there were many comments about a possible change of emphasis, considering the wines chosen: no Burgundy or Rhône at all; only one Bordeaux, and that a minor one. In truth my concern was only to show that students should not have clear expectations. The exam will cover many areas and aspects of our industry, but the wines chosen can never be guessed at. Studies of what has been shown recently and what is likely to “come up” are likely to be a waste of time. Simply prepare yourself for anything – and, yes, I am aware that it’s never simple!

This year Philip Tuck MW stood down as the Chair of the Practical Exam (Practical Chair), so I managed the Practical Paper whilst also overseeing the whole exam. (I was previously Practical Chair for six years, before handing over to Philip). This year I introduced the new marking system whereby each Paper has a ‘Paper Chair’, who moderates that paper’s results before the full set of marks came to me for a final, thorough consideration of all possible passing candidates. Next year one of those Paper Chairs, Peter Marks (our most experienced examiner) will take over as the Practical Chair. He is from California and is based there. However, please do not expect a change of emphasis. He will instruct his team to produce papers that give the best possible test of your tasting and communication ability; nothing else is ruled out or in.

b) Paper 1 report - Paper Chair, Ulf Sjödin MW

A copy/paste of last year's comments could easily be applied this year. Far too many students use just "good" and "very good" to address quality. Candidates should take some time thinking about what is actually expected from someone working in the wine trade. The ability to determine a wine's quality and value is arguably more important than being able to identify a wine blind. Successful candidates used shelf price and/or wordings like "high quality estate wine but not at single vineyard level" to try to express how the wine is positioned on the market.

Basic winemaking knowledge is also an issue. Students need to learn about fermentation temperatures for different styles of wine, reasonable maceration times and how wines with different degrees of sweetness are made.

Question 1

Almost all students identified Sauvignon Blanc in the first flight, and many students did well on this question. Alcohol levels proved difficult for most students, and while some managed to put wine 4 as reasonably low, it was rare to see someone going as far as 9.5%. In fact, far too many were at 13% alcohol and there was a considerable number of students who confused the lightness of the wine with elegance, and placed wine 4 as a high-quality Sancerre. Students must take time tasting high volume wines to understand the bulk business better. This is obviously a key part of the wine business and students who only taste at the top level will not master wine. Wine 3 was generally the best answered wine, although many overestimated the quality and thought it was a top château. Some regions are hard to spell, but (in addition to being wrong) Entre-deux-Mers was invariably spelled incorrectly when chosen as the origin.

Question 2

The pair from Spain was often well answered. Some students used the Portuguese word Alvarinho for some reason, and a few students failed to state Viura for the white Rioja, leaving examiners wondering if that was due to a lack of knowledge or time pressure. For the Italian pair, most students managed to identify wine 8 as a Moscato from Piemonte.

Surprisingly, there seemed to be confusion between the styles of Moscato d'Asti and Asti Spumante, stating alcohol levels for one but identifying the wine as the other. Candidates must remember that the Practical Paper is also a test of theoretical knowledge, and easy marks were lost by those who showed that lack of knowledge. Since wine 8 clearly pointed

to Italy, many candidates were able to use this as part of the argument for the origin of wine 7. The examiners were aware that wine 7 was a difficult wine to identify, and many reasonable answers were able to gain at least 6 of the 12 marks, more if there was good reasoning showing that the student knew his/hers way around Italian whites. Unfortunately, this was rare. Most students immediately went for Pinot Grigio, but only those who could argue well maximized their marks.

The last pair was often well answered, even by those students who went wrong with the country of origin. France was the most common alternative, many taking the Clare Valley Riesling for a Chenin Blanc from the Loire, or even a Muscadet. It was clear that wine 10 was the wine which decided country of origin, and then there was some shoe-horning to get wine 9 right. Those who went to Australia got very good marks in general, but there seems to be a low level of knowledge of New World regions. Some went directly for an apparently random area; it was difficult for examiners to know if this was because of genuine recognition of a regional style, or because the candidate didn't know any other options and so couldn't argue for and against them.

Question 3

This question was a test of how well students could read wines that are more or less impossible to identify. No marks were given for attempts on identification. Most students identified wine 11 as an "orange wine" and many managed to recognize the underlying quality, while also noting the oxidation, volatility and brett that could also be seen as faults. Some answers were very good, and most students did reasonably well.

Wine 12 was more difficult and many candidates showed a limited ability in reading the wine, instead immediately deciding that it was an amontillado and writing the answers from that. This was not a question where the old rule "go for the first impression" was relevant. Instead, both wines needed a thorough examination, using the other old rule "taste like a detective; argue like a lawyer". The best students showed deep understanding of both wines and had no problem in identifying the high quality and the limited commercial potential. Lack of knowledge on winemaking were evident in many papers. Three days pre-soak before pressing doesn't give a wine a distinct tannic structure, nor is it possible to get these tannin levels just from oak ageing.

c) Paper 2 report - Paper Chair, Peter Mitchell MW

Please read the questions carefully; as plenty did not. Some examples: Syrah mentioned in flight 1; answers in flight 2 that wasted time by justifying a new world origin; also in flight 2 having two wines from the same country; flight 3 wines in Lebanon (which is not in Europe); or suggesting wines from France or Italy. Several candidates addressed quality but barely mentioned commercial potential.

On the subject of commercial and market questions, candidates need to talk about a wine in a global perspective. Far too many (mostly from the US and UK) only consider where a wine would be positioned in their own market, ignoring other countries and the relevant domestic market, which in many cases would be the most important.

With a quality assessment, just stating 'good' or 'very good' does not mean much in itself and will not earn much credit. It needs to be contextualised, either with an appropriate price range, or by comparing it to the quality of other wines from the region.

A lot of candidates, even when identifying the wine correctly, are then very vague about how they got there, with leaps such as 'warm climate leads to Mendoza'. For every part of the question there needs to be a logical and pragmatic argument to justify the conclusion. This also means more marks can be given when the conclusion is wrong, as we can then see and reward intelligent thinking.

Bullet points (or similar) are obviously a good idea if you have run out of time. However they rarely make for a strong argument, and are unlikely to inspire confidence in an examiner.

Question 1

On the face of it quite straightforward, this question proved much more difficult for the candidates than flights 2 or 3. MWs who tasted the flight blind, and a handful of candidates, managed to identify either the origin or the dominant variety in each case, encouraging me to believe that the wines were not in fact too hard, but that many are simply not sufficiently well versed in Bordeaux varieties around the world. Very few candidates even considered Italy and some that did were unclear about relevant styles made around the country. The better candidates managed to score good marks with logical arguments, even when incorrect, by being accurate on both quality and maturity.

Wine 1 was picked as Bordeaux by the majority. Far too many candidates mistook its maturity for quality, with a large number placing this as a top-quality, left-bank Cru Classé.

Wine 2, as mentioned, was rarely identified as Italian, but good candidates gained marks by recognising the excellent quality.

Whilst wine 3 was the best answered in the flight, a good number mistook the bright fruit character for Australia or Chile, despite the relatively restrained alcohol, elevated acidity and tannic structure.

Wine 4 was often confused for Bordeaux – a classic mistake and one which didn't necessarily forfeit too many marks. But a clear pointer for practise in the future.

The majority of candidates displayed a lack of technical knowledge of red winemaking, specifically over likely maceration times and fermentation temperatures and the effects they have on the finished wine. Many did not even mention extraction techniques or time on skins when discussing winemaking and a fair number believe that red wines are generally fermented in barrel, rather than this still being a relative rarity. Bottle age is not a winemaking technique.

Question 2

The wording of the question gave a lot of help here and with three of the wines 'benchmarks', flight 2 turned out to be the easiest for the majority of candidates, with many scoring a high pass.

There would appear to be a blind spot for a sizable minority over Uruguay and those who considered it often appeared to have little knowledge about what makes a wine Uruguayan. 'It's Tannat so it's Uruguay' did not get full marks. Only one candidate considered Tannat from other places (despite the fact it is made in Argentina, Brazil, and to a limited extent in California and Virginia).

Market position was poorly answered by a large number who either thought naming a price covered this or saying it would work well in a steakhouse. To score well, candidates need to consider which market a wine style is likely to sell in (domestic/export, global/regional) and type of retailer – very few did.

Question 3

Often tackled well, this was arguably the easiest question to score points on, as most of the marks were for discussing quality, maturity and commercial potential, rather than precise identification. This did however require a little rigour and less successful candidates drifted in to writing a tasting note or discussing food matching. Great latitude was given on the possible origin and grape variety part of the question, however candidates did need to come

to a conclusion rather than just list half a dozen things they thought it might be. Wine 9 was the best answered with many recognising the high quality, despite its lack of obvious richness.

d) Paper 3 report Paper Chair, Peter Marks MW

In Paper 3, the candidates who performed well demonstrated both a strong technical knowledge and a writing style that convincingly linked what they know about production with how the wine tastes in the glass. There were very few outstanding papers, but many borderline passes.

Many may have felt they did well after the exam because their general identifications were close for 8 or 9 of the wines. But in most cases quality, style and winemaking were much more important - and this is where so many did poorly. Identification of origin isn't necessarily a clear prelude to success or failure in a paper like this.

Many answers appeared repetitious or formulaic. This only makes sense if the wines tasted similarly, which the examiners did their best to ensure was not the case! The best candidates managed to tease out the intrinsic differences between groups of wines and show how they reflected qualitative and winemaking differences.

- Use the "funnelling" technique for when the identity of a wine is unclear, or you are uncertain. It is good to show consideration of other possible answers but in most cases try to narrow the field to two or three options to avoid wasting precious time and showing a lack of confidence.
- In general, there were longer answers from those who typed than from those who hand wrote the exam. This can mean more points, but it can also mean quite a bit of waffling.
- It is dangerous to second-guess examiners; much better to just look at what's in the glass. Create a tasting system that helps you question your first initial response, just in case a little RS on a rosé does not mean a White Zinfandel.

Question 1

Generally well answered with most candidates successfully identifying the wines as Champagnes. The best answers spotted the difference between the NV and Vintage and noted that wine 2 was the superior example with longer ageing/lees contact, use of oak, no MLF and lower dosage. Answers for method of production could have been better. Many candidates failed to address all the primary facets such as grape varieties, fermentation vessel, MLF, time on the lees and dosage levels, or failed to compare/contrast. Few could detect the predominance of Pinot Noir/Meunier (40% each) in wine 1. With 50% of the marks devoted to style, quality and commercial appeal, valuable points could be gained

here even if the wines were misidentified. The best commercial answers described markets, occasions, placement and pricing (including pricing promotion for wine #1) particular to each wine.

Question 2

Wines 3 and 4 were well recognized as Prosecco but the majority of students felt that the simple DOC version was in fact superior to the DOCG wine. Perhaps candidates confused an earthy quality in wine 4 for minerality and thought it was a wine marked by more terroir. Or, coming right after the Champagnes, the sweetness of wine 3 may have led many to believe it was the inferior of the two wines. This latter reason may be the case since many candidates found wine 3 sweeter than wine 4, even though wine 4 was sweeter than wine 3 (by 3 g/L), and many thought wine 4 was a brut. The key here was to recognize the delicacy, finesse and fine balance of wine 3 vs. the bitterness and short finish of wine 4. Given the large quantity of marks available in part B, this question impacted many papers' overall grading. That said, when the quality of the wines was correctly identified there were many good commercial appeal answers.

Question 3

The four rosés were a challenge to identify, but the questions were structured in a way that prevented misidentification of origin from affecting candidates' performances too adversely. Many successfully identified the Provence and quite a few answered the Rioja and Pinot Noir questions well, while the NZ example was inevitably difficult to pinpoint. Candidates need to understand the range of rosés that are now available - it is beyond just Provence and White Zinfandel. In fact, many candidates were looking for residual sugar and finding it where it wasn't. Nonetheless, most of the marks were devoted to method of production, quality, style and commercial positioning. Candidates need to know the effect of different winemaking techniques on the resulting wine - saignée, maceration (duration and temperature), and direct press. Those candidates who demonstrated a solid understanding of rosé winemaking and styles in the marketplace stood out, but many answers were vague or too general. Many students tried to find the "inevitable" White Zinfandel, to their misfortune.

Question 4

Perhaps the best answered question on the paper. Candidates should practice tasting Fino and Manzanilla together in order to maximize points. Many strong answers here showed a good grasp of production methods and (crucially) were able to link them back to what is in

the glass. Impressively, almost all candidates identified the Jura (although a couple got confused with Jurancon!) but, perhaps inevitably, assumed it was a flor-influenced Vin Jaune from Savagnin (which would probably have higher alcohol) rather than an oxidatively raised Chardonnay (with a touch of flor character). Most could see that this was a unique and very high-quality wine. Commercial position responses for the Manzanilla ranged from inspired consideration of new markets, cocktails and the competitive set, as well as the challenges of selling higher alcohol wines, to the more mundane “serve with tapas.”

Question 5

There was a real split of answers here which divided the candidates who clearly knew the styles of wine and those that clearly didn't. Most candidates recognized the Rutherglen Muscat but were either unfamiliar with Passito styles or were rushed for time at the end and ended up finding botrytis, icewine or fortified wine when there was none. Few could adequately describe and compare and contrast the production methods. It always puts serious doubts in the mind of the examiner when theory knowledge is lacking.

Following Peter's final sentence above, some examples of 'clangers' that illustrate his point.

Vin Jeune (written three times – all other spellings in the answer correct).

Oloroso Dulce (no longer exists).

“Suggesting California Cabernet and a region such as Santa Barbara”.

Cerasuolo from (the region of) Montepulciano.

‘Rivesaltes de Minervois’.

“Pale colour is indicative of France or Spain” (rosé question).

*“Ripe roundness of fruit more consistent with Sonoma Coast than other areas in California”
Sanlucar, Catalonia.*

And the incessant use of PREMIUM or LOWER PREMIUM – please do read previous reports for my (JH) feelings on this.